

Melissomelos

Bees' melody, commonly called the 'Bee madrigal'

Charles Butler (d. 1647)

Complete edition by Magnus Williamson for the *Bee-ing Human* project (Leverhulme Trust, 2022-25). First performed complete by Ensemble Pro Victoria, Newcastle University, 29 February 2024.

Melissomelos

(the so-called 'Bee madrigal')

Charles Butler

STC 4193, sigs. L1-2

Meane Contratenor

Tenor Bassus

1

1. As of all states the Mo - nar - chie is best,
 2. They work in com - mon for the com - mon weale:

3. When so in - creased is this pru - dent na - tion
 4. To whose graue ac - cents if hir Prince - ly Grace

4

om 1634

So of all Mo - nar - chies that Fe - mi - nine, Of fa - mous
 Their la - bour's rest - lesse to main - taine their state: Their Hex - a -

That their owne li - mits can - not them suf - fice; To seeke new
 Vouch - safe with Trine As - pect re - ply to make, To sweet - est

8

om 1634

A - ma - zons ex - cels the rest, That on this ear - thie Sphære haue e - uer bin,
 - go - ni - a no Be - za - lell for cu - rious Art, may passe or im - i - tate,

ci - ties for new Ha - bi - ta - tion, They send a - broad their num' - rous Co - lo - nies:
 Tre - ble tu - ning swee - ter Base: Hir mourne - full suit a ioy - full end doth take:

∞. verse 2?

13

Whose lit - tle hearts in wea - ker sex (so great in field) No pow - ers
 One Sou' - raign, and but one, com - mands-----this peo - ple loyall, the great Mar -

An - ti - o - pe the prime Prince gone, O - ri - thya soone Of hir Queene -
 And then, when fit time they es - py, Some thou - sands strong This Ar - mie



18 om 1634

of the might-iest Males can make to yeeld: They li - uing aye, most so - ber
pese with plen - ty blest of is - sue royall: An - ti - o - pe, and O - ri-

mo - ther, ma - king mone, Begs the like boone: That with hir traine hir for - tune
roy - all gal - lant - ly Doth march a - long. Harke, harke, me thinks I heare in

23 *Fine*

and most chast, Their paine-got goods in plea - sure scorne to wast.
thy - ia faire, With o - ther Prin - ces hir In - fan - tas are.

she may seeke: And this she sings in mea - sures mourn - full sweete.
Notes of choice, This fair - est La - dies swee - test mourn - full voice.

Repeat *dal segno* Φ on final repeat of v. 1 only

27 new $\circ$ = old $\circ$

Meane

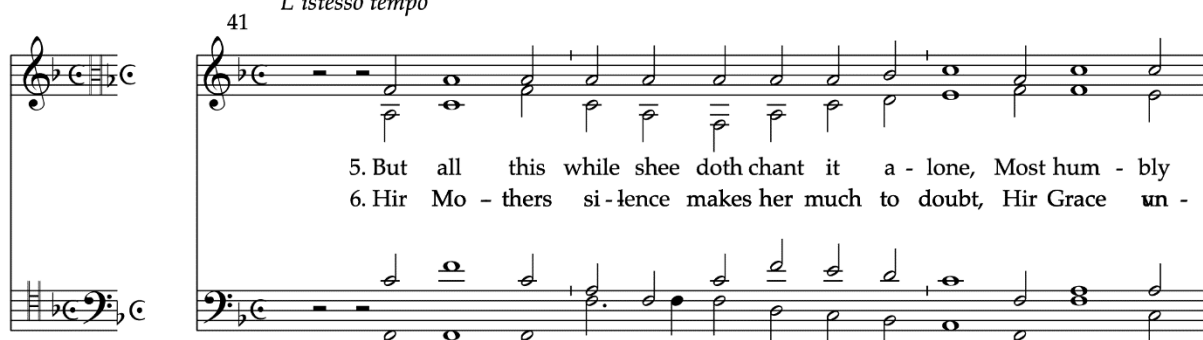
30

34

37

L'istesso tempo

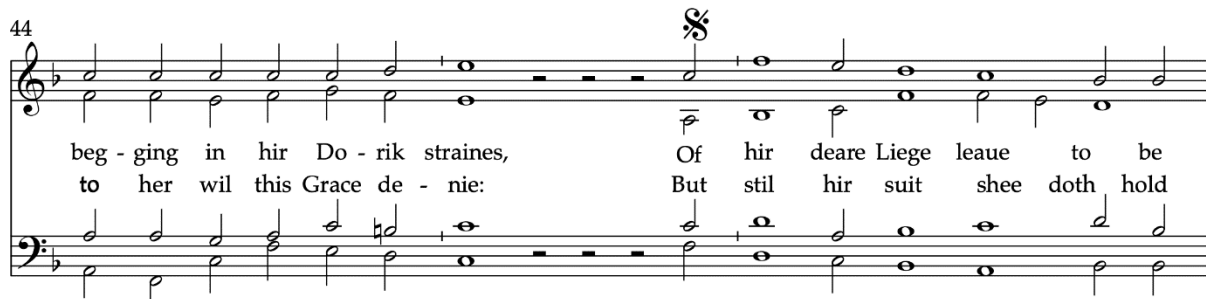
41



5. But all this while shee doth chant it a-lone, Most hum-bly
6. Hir Mo-thers si-lence makes her much to doubt, Hir Grace un-

7. Im-port'-nate O-ri-thy-ia nou hath woon Hir sterne Queene-
8. These La-dies Mu-si-call Con-sort as-sures. The Prince his
9. Where tread-ing the Héy, right nim-bly theyprance, Thus wait-ing
Or 'tread-ing the Héy'

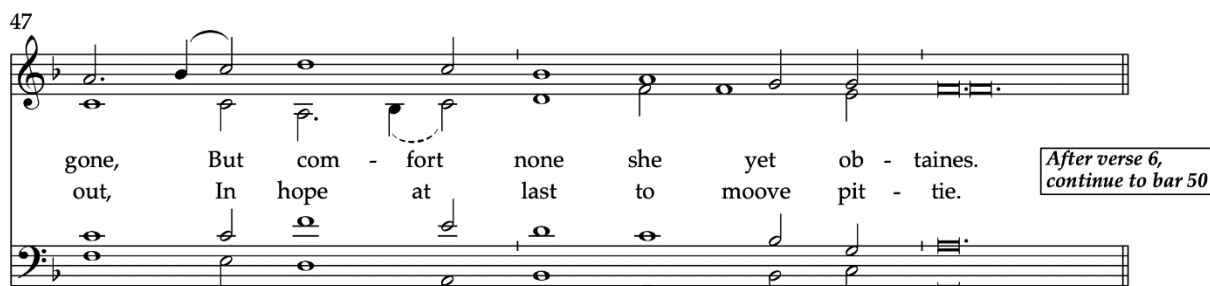
44



beg-ging in hir Do-rik straines, Of hir deare Liege leaue to be
to her wil this Grace de-nie: But stil hir suit shee doth hold

Mo-thers gránt to hír de-sire: For Joy, hir Sis-ters all as
much-de-si-red Sov'-raign-tie: The vul-gar when oc-ca-s'on
their Prince, in and out they trace: Who coom, these Maids the Mo-rice

47

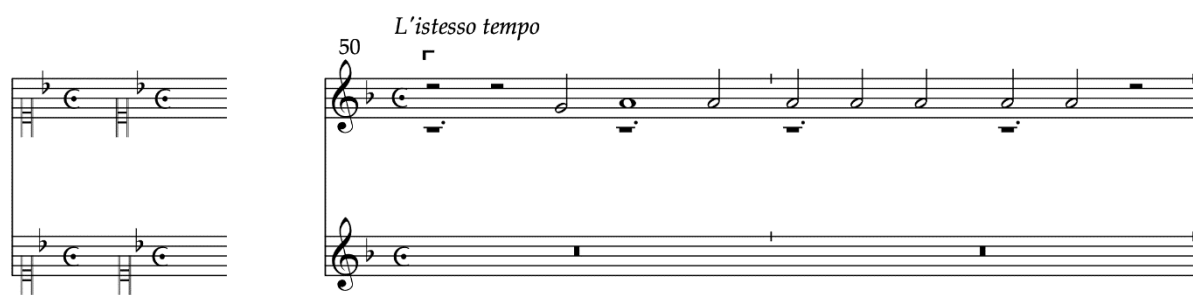


gone, But com-fort none she yet ob-taines. After verse 6,
continue to bar 50
out, In hope at last to moove pit-tie.

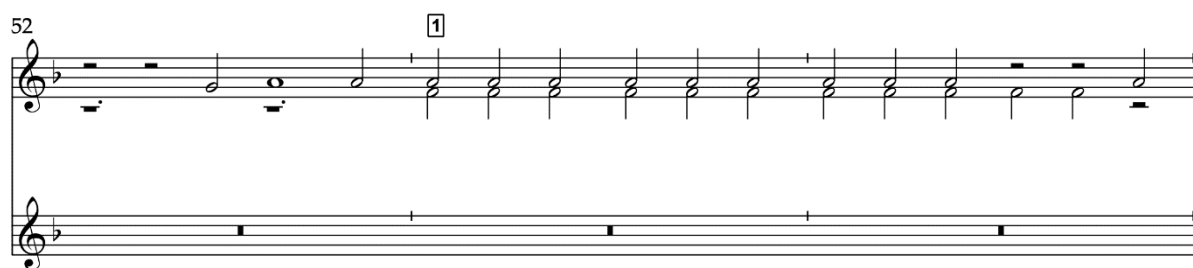
one With cheere - full tones fill vp the Quire.
servs, (this watch - woord past) a - broad dooe hie. After verse 9,
DA CAPO Verse 1
dance, A - long un - to their rest - ing place.

Before verse 7: Sing this Ditti to the second Tune; repeating the two last strains of the last Staf: and then end with the first verse of the first Song; repeating the two last strains therof. This implies *dal segno* repeats of the second halves of verses 9 and 1 (*da capo*) only.

50 *L'istesso tempo*



52 1



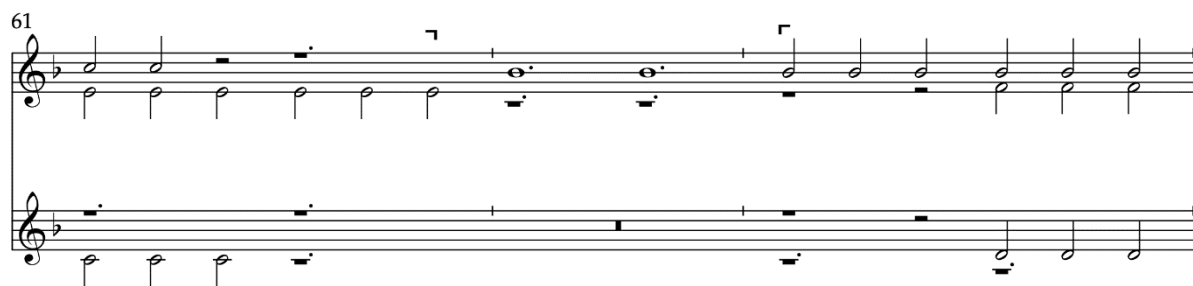
55 2



58 3



61



64

64 65 66

67

67 68 69

62

70

70 71 72

4

73

73 74 75

76

76 77

DAL SEGNO % *Return to verse 7*

Editions

- 1623 Charles Butler, *The Feminine Monarchie or the History of Bees* (London: John Haviland for Roger Jackson, 1623; RSTC 4193), sigs. [K4]v, L[1]r-v, L2r
- 1634 Charles Butler, *The feminin^e monarchi^e, or the histori of bee^s* (Oxford: William Turner for the author, 1634; RSTC 4194), pp. 78-81 (sigs. L3v, [L4]r-v, M[1]r). This includes phonetic spelling of text underlay and revisions by Butler to syllabification of text underlay, punctuation, deletion of semibreve rests between lines and one instance of part-writing

Copies consulted

- 1623 **Cambridge**, University Library, Keynes S.1.29; **Cambridge**, University Library, Syn.7.62.248; **Cornell** University Library (via IMSLP); **London**, British Library, C.118.bb.1(2); **London**, British Library, Cup.405.i.21.3; **Paris**, Bibliothèque Nationale, Tolbiac S3409.Wisconsin/Hathi Trust;
- 1634 **Cambridge**, University Library (via EEBO); **London**, Wellcome Library (via IMSLP); John Waterer collection (via Sotheby's catalogue).

Other copies

- 1623 **Canterbury** Cathedral Library; National Library of Scotland (MRB.107); **Chicago**, Northwestern University (595.79 B97); **Chicago**, Newberry Library (Case O 97 .128); **Göttingen**, Niedersächsische Staats- und Universitätsbibliothek (8DGZool.VI,9512); New Zealand: Rothamsted Experimental Station, **Harpenden**; **British Library** (Cup.405.i.21/3 or C.118.bb.1(2).); **Lansing**, Library of Michigan (xx SF 525 .B8 1623); **London**, University College Library: Strong Room OGDEN A 522; **London** University Library ([D.-L.L.] Y10 [Butler]); **London**, Natural History Museum (ENTOMOLOGY SPECIAL BOOKS O B.29.); **Madison**, University of Wisconsin-Madison, Memorial Library (Thordarson T474); **New Haven**, Beinecke (Sth12 350); **Oxford**, Bodleian Library (Vet. A2 e.22 (5) and Vet.A2e.22(8).); **Oxford**, Merton College, Oxford (75.F.5(6).); **Oxford**, St John's College (HB4/3.a.5.22); **Providence**, John Carter Brown Library; **San Marino**, Huntington Library (357272); **Washington DC**, Folger Shakespeare (STC 4193, Copy 1 and 4193 Copy 2); **Wellington**, Alexander Turnbull Library, National Library of New Zealand (REng.BUTLER.Femi.1623); **Williamstown** College Library.
- 1634 46 copies are listed on USTC

Tempo relationships: in imperfect time throughout, with minor prolation in verses 1-4 and major prolation thereafter. Butler's notation of the void semibreves in bar 32 confirms that one imperfect semibreve has the same temporal duration as one full black perfect semibreve. This conforms with Butler's own precept: 'The principal *Time*-note is the *Semibrief*: by whose Time, the time of all Notes is known'(Charles Butler, *The Principles of Musik in Singing and Setting* (London: John Haviland for the author, 1636; RSTC 4196), p. 24).

Abbreviations:

- Part-names: M = Meane/Medius, C = Contratenor, T = Tenor, B = Bassus.
- Note values: *b* = brevis/breve, *L* = longa/long, *m* = minima/minim, *s* = semibrevis/semibreve.
- Mensuration signs: cut-C sig = imperfect time with minor prolation (simple duple time), C-dot sig = imperfect time with major prolation (compound duple time).
- Other: col = coloured, dot = dotted

Critical Notes

2 C 1623 no slur DE

2, verse 3, Butler does not clearly syllabify 'increased is this prudent nation'; other solutions include subdividing the second minim of b. 2 ('is this') and then assigning trisyllabic 'na-ti-on' to the three chords of b. 3. Unfortunately, the phonetic typesetting in 1634 fails to elucidate this.

7 all voices 1623 s-rest before first note

7-9, verse 2, all voices 1623 'Hexa-gonia no Be-za-leell', placement suggesting ligation of '-nia' and division of 'leell' (but 'leell' rhymes with 'weale')

8, verse 3, Butler does not clearly syllabify 'for new Habitation'; other solutions include subdividing the third and fourth chords of b. 8 ('for new / Ha-bi') and assigning '-ta-ti-on' to b. 9.

11 T 1623 1634 mD recte mB?

13 all voices 1623 s-rest before first note

14 C 1634 flat to E

20 all voices 1623 'roy-all' for 'royall' (but rhymes with 'loyall', one syllable); all voices 1623 s-rest after bar line

22-23 C 1623 mF mD mF mF mE sF for mF mD mD mC mC sF

24 all voices 1623 s-rest before first note

26 all voices 1623 'Infantaes' for 'Infantas'

27 M 1623 C-dot sig; C T B 1623 C1 clef, C-dot sig, 7 L-rests

31 M 1634 second dot-s-rest omitted

32 M 1623 cut-C sig, sA sA both void

33 M 1623 C-dot sig?

40 M 1623 col bA undotted

41 B 1634 cut-C sig for C-dot sig

47 M 1634 dot omitted to dot-mA

50 C 1623 1 L-rest, 1 b-rest; T 1623 4 L-rests, 1 b-rest; B 1623 3 L-rests, 1 b-rest

52 M 1623 '1' above 1A

57 M 1623 '2' above 1B

59 M 1623 '3' above 1C

61 C 1623 ⁵mE misprinted by rotation of character to mB, manually corrected in all inspected copies.

62 M 1623 cut-C sig, void sB sB; C T B 1 col b-rest (no change of sig)

67 B 1623 '62' above ⁵D, meaning unclear

70 T 1623 '4' above 1C

78 all voices 1634 'Sing this Ditti to the second Tune; repeating the two last strains of the last Staf: and then end with the first verse of the first Song; repeating the two last strains therof'